

**Maskwa**

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## **Taking Away**

Loss of culture is something all indigenous peoples have faced as a result of colonialism; my band is no different. We are unique, however, in that our loss of culture was augmented by the complete enfranchisement of our band, the Michel First Nation, in 1958. Prior to this, the band signed on to Treaty 6 by way of an adhesion in 1878. As a party to Treaty 6, the band was entitled to agriculture equipment, among other things. Despite this, in the early 1900s, the band was pressured to surrender parts of its reserve in exchange for the promised agricultural equipment. Starting in the 1920s many individual members of the band began to enfranchise in order to access the rights and freedoms afforded to non-indigenous Canadians. This became increasingly necessary for many members because the reserve lands were constantly shrinking and agricultural subsistence became virtually impossible. Without a means to support and feed their families, many members were forced to enfranchise. Many members also choose to enfranchise as a way to avoid having their children forced to attend residential school.

By 1958, with a large number of band members already enfranchised, and the reserve lands constantly shrinking, the entire Michel band was enfranchised. This meant that the band and reserve were dissolved, and small parcels were allocated to each enfranchised adult member of the band. This was not done by means of taking scrip, instead it was meant to serve as a model for the federal government to assimilate first nations across the country, making Michel First Nation quite unique. Fortunately, this model did not take form, and Michel has been the only band to enfranchise in such a way. One of the unfortunate results of enfranchisement has been the loss of individual status for Michel people. Slowly, many individuals have been able to regain their Indian status following the passage of Bill C-31 and later following the McIvor &

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The content of this paper is derived from oral histories and traditional knowledge from elders and family members.

Descheneaux Supreme Court decisions. To this day, however, the Michel band is not recognized by the Government of Canada. There remains one individual member who kept his originally allocated parcel of land on the old reserve. The rest of the old Michel reserve land has been sold and developed. Lacking a land base, the rest of the remaining Michel members and descendants are largely scattered across western Canada.

In addition to the band enfranchisement, the Michel band was also subject to the same colonial policies that other first nations endured. Many members of the Michel First Nation were forced to attend residential schools, including my maternal grandmother & great grandmother. The intergenerational effects of this are apparent within my family, including a loss of culture and language. My Grandmother and her siblings retained their Cree language abilities despite their schooling, however, they did not pass this to my mother's generation. My family has also been affected by the missing and murdered indigenous women and girls crisis. One of my aunties went missing in the 1980s on Vancouver's downtown east side, joining a group of vulnerable, often indigenous women that went missing in that region over a span of several decades. In addition, my older half-sister was a victim of the sixties scoop after being adopted to a non-indigenous family as a newborn.

Another unfortunate result of our band's enfranchisement and other colonial policies we've endured has been lateral violence. Within my own family this has been an issue. Within the band more broadly, lateral violence has become a major issue in recent years. As the legal & political landscapes have changed over the past few decades, and reconciliation more widely accepted, the Michel First Nation has sought band reinstatement. This has caused a divide within our nation largely due to the issue of Indian status. While many members have been able to regain their individual status, there are many descendants who are unable to either because their

ancestors took scrip or because their situations do not fit within what is recognized in the Indian Act. Consequently, there is division amongst the band about how best to proceed to rectify what happened to the Michel band back in 1958. We also lack organization, leadership and financial resources. Despite having the opportunity in 2017 to begin discussions with the federal government on how to proceed with band reinstatement, we have been unable to made any progress because of the deep divide amongst our people. Without a unified voice representing the band, the government is unwilling to proceed with these discussions. It seems until we as a people come together, we will be unable to move forward.

### **Kawôtinikewin**

Ewako ôma ohci  
sôpêkahikan maskwa pihtaw mistahi  
ispihteyhtakosowin nêhiyawîhtwâwin.  
Maskwa nîkâneyihtâkosiwin âtayôhkan  
nehiyawak. Wahkomakan ayisiniwak ekwa  
pahki nihtâwihcikewin âcimowin. Maskwa  
nimosôminan pihci nêhiyaw  
nihtâwihcikewin âcimowin. Maskwa  
awîyak kakiskeyihtâhk neheyaw maskihkîy  
ekwa petaw maskihkîy pahkisimôtâhk  
ochi. Niya ochi Mohawk ochi etah ka  
ohtâskanesihk maskwa.

### **Taking Back**

For this assignment I decided to paint  
a bear. The reason I chose a bear as my  
subject is because of its strong meaning  
within the Cree culture. The bear is  
recognized as the strongest spirit for Cree  
people. This is because it is considered a  
relative to humans and is part of the creation  
story for the Cree people. Through the Cree  
creation story, the bear is seen as a  
grandfather and accordingly, is often still  
referred to as a grandfather now. Bears are  
also recognized as medicine keepers and bring

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I have chosen to write the portion of this paper that explains the meaning behind my painting in Cree language. The rough translation to English is also provided for reference. Writing in Cree is a way for me to honour an important part of my personal growth as well as to honour the message of the bear teachings, which I explain in the paper.

Ketasinastek nîkâneyihtâkosiwin.  
Mihko naspisihcikan nehiyawak.  
Mihkonikâtêw mamihcitotamowin oye  
ekwa nitiyinîmak. Sîpihko ekwa  
askehtakawa naspisihcikan pisiskow  
acahkwak. Astamihk pahkisimôtâhk  
maskihkîy wâskâpayîs ketasinastek sîpihko  
ekwa askehtakawa ekwa maskwa pisiskow  
acahkwak. Naspisihcikan kîsohpikiwin,  
nâkateyimowewin ekwa  
pekweyihtamowin.

Nia kakehk maskwa sisopekaha  
sîpihko ekwa askehtakawa naspisihcikan  
pahkisimôtâhk kihcêyihtâkwan niya wiya  
ekwa niya peyakôskân. Kîyânaw  
wanisinowin nehiyawewin ekwa  
nehiyawewin. Kîyânaw wanisinowin  
wâhkôhtamowin. Maskihkîy  
pahkisimôtâhk ochi ispîhk kîyânaw  
nistawinâkewin maskwa âtayôhkan.  
Nimosôminan maskwa âtayôhkan  
nokohtâwin wahkomâkanak kihchi. Niya  
pakoseyimiw itasinâsonak ekwa âtayôhkan

our people medicines from the west. Along  
with that, I come from the bear clan through  
my Mohawk roots, so the bear has special  
meaning to me through that as well.

The colours I've chosen for this  
painting also have meaning. The colour red  
represents the Cree people. I chose to use this  
colour as the background for this piece to  
acknowledge my people and heritage. The  
colours blue and green are meant to  
symbolize nature, animals, and other beings.

On the Cree medicine wheel, the west  
direction is a dark blue or green. This  
direction on the wheel holds the bear as its  
spirit animal. It also is a representation of  
adulthood, a deeper emotional understanding,  
and a time for taking responsibility.

I choose to paint the bear in blue and  
green tones to represent the importance of the  
west direction wheel teachings at this point in  
time both for myself and for my band.  
Following our enfranchisement and other  
colonial policies, our band lost so much of

sihkiskâkew nâkateyimowewin niyâk ekwa  
nîsopayihcikewin. Kîyânaw  
nisitohtamowin kiya oye ekwa  
nisitohtamowin wahkohtowak.  
Mihcetweyakisiwak ochi oye namatakon.

Mastaw, maskwa âtayôhkan  
pihtikwe niya pimâtisiwin ekwa petâw  
maskihkîy pahkisimôtâhk ochi. Peyakwâw  
nehiyawewin tahtapipimohtewin. Ana  
miyin âniskômohcikewin mâmawinitowin  
ekwa kiskinwâswêwita. Niya  
mâmitonêyihamowin namoya ihtakon  
Nakahpêhanohk, maka niya otihtikow  
maskihkîy omisimâw Vancouver ochi.  
Niya tâpwehtamowin maskwa  
nimosôminan petâw maskihkîy  
pahkisimôtâhk ochi.

Niya macihtaw pahkisimôtâhk  
tânispî ekwa nâkateyimowewin ochi  
nitawi-ayamihcikêw oyasiwewin. Niya  
nôhtê wichih nitiyinîmak sâposci  
kiskinwahamâkosiwin oyasiwewin.  
Kîkway kâwi tôtamihk. Ispîhk oskinîkiw

our culture and language. Beyond that we also  
lost important connections. I think by  
recognizing the bear spirit, we will allow for  
medicines from the west to be brought to us.  
The bear spirit being our grandfather will  
show people the importance of recognizing  
our ancestors and history. My hope is that the  
meaning of these colours and this spirit will  
inspire our band to take responsibility for our  
future and come together. By having a deeper  
emotional understanding, we can hopefully  
understand our past and recognize we are all  
related and descend from the same ancestors.  
Whatever divisions we've had in the past  
should stay in the past as we begin a new  
stage of life, the west direction of the wheel.  
This is also a way for us to integrate Cree law  
in our interactions with Canadian law.

Personally, I have more recently  
allowed spirits like the bear to enter my life  
and bring medicines from the west. This  
began for me with Cree language class, but  
through my participation in the class, I have

kiskinwahamakosiwin nehiyawiwîn ekwa  
nehiyawewîn, wiyawâw maskihkîy  
nitiyînîmak. Maskwa âtayôhkan ekwa  
pahkisimôtâhk nîsohkamâkewîn nisitohta  
oye ekwa nîsohkamâtowak yahkipita.  
Kîyânaw itôtâmowîn maskihkîy  
pahkisimôtâhk ochi maskwa petâw ekwa  
mâcihta yahkipita. Hiy hiy. Kakiyaw  
niwakohmakanak.

received so much more medicine than simply  
language. I have made connections with a  
community of Cree people. I have also  
received cultural teachings and been able to  
participate in ceremony through these  
connections, things that I thought were  
impossible to receive in Vancouver before  
starting to take these classes. Despite being  
the people of the plains, I have been very  
fortunate to receive this medicine in  
Vancouver from incredible matriarchs. I  
believe this is grandfather bear bringing me  
his medicine from the west.

I think in returning to school to study  
law, I have already entered the west phase of  
life and taken more responsibility and begun  
to try to gain a deeper emotional  
understanding. I hope through studying law,  
to one day be able to help my band on its path  
forward. This is a personal responsibility I  
believe I have. I also think that as more youth  
from my band begin to study language and  
learn more about our culture, they will also

serve as medicine to our people. I am hopeful that the embodiment of the bear spirit and the west direction will help us understand our past and ultimately move our band forward. We as a people can act as the medicine from the west that the bear brings and begin our path forward. Thank you. All my relations.